



CHAPTER ONE

[LOCATION: EARTH]

[RUN: UNSET]

“Don’t follow me. Wait for the fire.”

Vharos has almost nothing left in his health bar. Neither do I. Twelve of us have spent three hours learning how to die in this room, and Liam is about to die trying to heal me.

“Nyx, you’re out of range.”

“I know. Stay there.”

Black flame spreads across the obsidian between my character and the raid. There’s a gap opening on the left, the same gap that killed me on the last pull. I keep my thumb off Blink. My damage numbers stop. For one horrible second I can see the argument we’re going to have if this costs us the record.

The flame thins.

“Now. Left. Everyone left.”

Nyx flashes through first. I turn the camera, count the bodies coming behind her, and start hitting the boss again before I’ve finished counting. Liam’s heal lands. Somebody is yelling the last percent into my ear as if the game needs encouragement.

“HE’S DOWN! HE’S FUCKING DOWN!”

The scream detonates through my headset half a second before six other voices pile on top of it, and Discord stops being a conversation and becomes weather. Somebody wants the timer checked. Somebody is already clipping it. Somebody keeps saying my handle like a chant, Nyx, Nyx, you beautiful bitch, and I'm laughing too hard to answer any of them.

On my monitor, Vharos the Undying collapses to his knees in a storm of black fire, his enormous health bar finally, finally empty. His sword hits the obsidian floor first. His body follows with enough force to shake the camera.

[VHAROS THE UNDYING: DEFEATED]

[MYTHIC CLEAR]

[NEW SERVER RECORD: 06:42]

"Six forty-two!"

"Somebody send it to Derek."

"Don't," I say, laughing into my hand. The bedroom wall is thin enough that I can hear my neighbor's television through it. "Let him find it."

A notification flashes in the corner of the screen.

Derek: fuck all of you

Too late.

There are eleven people watching my stream. Eleven. Not exactly the screaming stadium I picture whenever I tell myself NyxLive is going to take off someday, but eleven people just watched us beat Derek's group by thirty-seven seconds, so tonight those eleven beautiful bastards are enough.

pixelwitch: LMAOOOOOO

BoredAtWork88: DEREK IN SHAMBLES

ManaAddict: nyx carried

Derek: banned

I lean toward my mic. "Thank you, ManaAddict. Finally, someone recognizes talent."

"You died twice," Liam says.

"Mechanics."

"You blinked into lava."

"Advanced mechanics."

My chat fills with laughing emotes and I grin at the monitor, because this stupid, perfect little pocket of the night is why I keep doing it. I want eleven thousand someday. Enough that NyxLive stops being the thing I squeeze between classes and closing shifts and becomes the thing that pays rent, enough that I can hand in my apron at Brewed Awakening and never again ask another human being whether they want room for cream. For six hours I haven't thought about tomorrow's class or the milk crusted under the steam wand at work. Liam is still arguing with chat about my damage numbers. I turn him up.

And Nyx just killed Vharos the fucking Undying.

My stomach growls loudly enough that Liam hears it through the mic.

"What the hell was that?"

"Betrayal." I pull the headset off one ear. "I need food."

"At two thirteen in the morning?"

"Yes, Mom."

"You have food?"

I look toward the kitchen. Technically. "Fuck you."

More laughter follows me into the kitchen, headset hanging off one ear. Seven steps from my desk, eight if I avoid the floorboard that sounds like a dying goose. The refrigerator hums beneath a cabinet door that hasn't closed properly since I moved in three months ago. Inside: ranch, three eggs, pickles, one slice of cheese, and a take-out container I am unwilling to acknowledge as mine. My emergency energy drink waits behind the milk.

Mom stood in this spot on move-in day with both refrigerator doors open.

"You know you can still come home, right?"

"I know."

"You could save money."

Dad appeared behind her carrying a box marked BATHROOM that contained my gaming speakers. "Your mother means please come home before this building kills you."

“This building is fine.”

Something crashed upstairs. We all looked at the ceiling.

Dad waited a beat. “Convincing.”

My bedroom at their house is probably cleaner than this entire apartment. Mom would feed me. Dad would pretend he wasn’t checking the oil in my car every time I visited. Another year there and I could save enough to transfer somewhere better than community college.

I nudge the crooked cabinet shut with my shoulder. It swings open again. Mine, at least.

I take two of the eggs and reach back for the ranch. Mom would have questions. I close the refrigerator before I can start answering them.

My phone lights up on the counter while I’m cracking them.

MAYA SZCZEPANIAK

My college email insists on displaying my full name in aggressive capital letters. I used to dread the pause before it on an attendance sheet. In fourth grade Mrs. Henderson made three attempts before I interrupted.

“Sheh-PAN-yak. Like chef, but he lost the F. Then pan, like you cook eggs in. Then yak. Like the hairy cow.”

“Chef without the F. Pan. Hairy cow.”

“Yes.”

“Sheh-pan-yak.”

I gave her a solemn nod. “You may continue.”

She had to hide her mouth behind the sheet while the class laughed. I’ve been running that bit for ten years. It works about half the time.

The email is a reminder about my nine o’clock. I swipe it away and the screen goes dark.

The eggs hiss in the pan.

“Shit.”

I rescue them a few seconds before they become charcoal, dump them onto a plate, and head back toward my desk with the food in one hand, the ranch bottle tucked against my ribs, and my phone gripped in my teeth, because I am not making two trips.

The boss’s corpse still sprawls across my screen. Discord is still going, my stream is still live, and Nyx stands in the center of the shattered throne room looking fucking immaculate.

Long pointed ears rise through silver-white hair. Her fitted black spellblade armor catches the dying glow of Vharos's flames in sharp lines of dark metal, with just enough exposed skin to make it abundantly clear that whoever designed the female elf armor understood their audience. I made her face as close to mine as the character creator would allow, same cheekbones, same mouth, same slightly up-turned nose.

Better hair, obviously.

I set the plate beside my keyboard and the phone faceup by my mouse pad. By the time I've settled the headset over both ears, Liam wants another run.

Derek joins our voice channel just in time to say, "Absolutely fucking not."

"We have the strat now."

"I have class at nine," I say around a mouthful.

"Nyx, it's two fifteen."

"Six hours of sleep. Practically responsible."

"That is not how math works."

I grin and take another bite. My shoulders ache from the hunch, my eyes are dry, and Nyx is still standing over a dead king. I should log off.

I drag my mouse over his body and open the loot window. Three items. The first is useless to me, the second is useful to somebody else, which makes it almost as boring, and I'm already moving toward the third when I read the name.

My fork stops halfway back to the plate. "Oh, you have got to be kidding me."

"What?" Liam asks.

I click it.

[VHAROS'S EMBERGLASS SABER]

The preview opens across the center of my screen. The blade is long and narrow, black enough that the edges almost disappear against the interface, and translucent fractures run through the metal from hilt to tip with something molten glowing beneath them in slow golden pulses.

Discord detonates.

"That's spellblade."

“You already got the shoulders.”

“You’re insufferable.”

“I know,” I say, and hit Need.

The roll spins. Ninety-eight.

“Oh, fuck off,” Liam says, and I laugh hard enough that I almost choke on cold egg.

pixelwitch: RIGGED

ManaAddict: streamer loot

Derek: i hate this game

I equip it. Gold pulses through the blade’s black fractures, lighting Nyx’s hand.

“You’re checking whether it matches,” Liam says.

The violet glow on her shoulders looks awful beside it.

“I might need to change my shoulders.”

“You changed your mog between pulls.”

“It gave me confidence.”

Derek launches into a speech about how people like me have destroyed gaming, and I’m still laughing when something slips sideways inside my head.

The laugh fades. My chair seems to lean beneath me, and I set the fork down before my hand can decide otherwise.

“You okay?” Liam asks.

“Yeah.”

The monitor is suddenly too bright. Embers in the throne room sharpen into orange needles. A high tone starts inside my ears; I lift an earcup, but it stays.

I look at the eggs. When did I buy them? Last week? I can’t find the purchase in my head.

“I think I poisoned myself.”

“With what?”

“The eggs.”

Somebody laughs. I wait for my stomach to settle.

The room lurches. My hand hits the edge of the desk hard enough to rattle the keyboard, the fork jumps against the plate with a metallic clink, and for a few seconds the apartment keeps moving even though nothing in it does.

Nobody laughs this time.

“Nyx?”

I hold on until the floor feels trustworthy again. “I’m...”

The word sticks. I move my tongue across the back of my teeth and it feels thick, slow. Swallowing should happen without instructions. Instead I have to think about it, and even then there’s a delay before my throat obeys.

“Maya?”

That gets my attention. Almost nobody here calls me Maya. Nyx is easier, Nyx is the name over my character and beside my messages and under my stream, and Liam knows my real name but uses it so rarely that hearing it through my headset changes the shape of the room.

I reach for my phone. My hand lands beside it.

The phone is right there, faceup near my mouse pad, and my fingers missed it by maybe two inches. I reach again, and my knuckles catch the case and knock it farther across the desk.

“Shit.”

“Maya, what’s happening?”

“I don’t know.”

The voices in Discord have begun to stretch. Everyone is still talking, but distance has crept into the sound and turned familiar voices thin around the edges. Liam asks me something. Derek says my name. Somebody talks across both of them. I catch call someone and lose the rest.

I push my chair back because I need to do something, and getting water is the first useful idea that survives long enough to act on. The wheels roll backward. The entire apartment rolls with them. Both hands lock around the edge of the desk while nausea sweeps through me, heavy enough to make my mouth flood.

“Maya, call somebody.”

“I’m fine.”

“You are clearly not fucking fine.”

“Maya, call your parents.”

“I’m nineteen.”

“What the fuck does that have to do with anything?”

There should be an answer. I can feel one, but the words won’t come.

My eyes drift back to the monitor. Nyx stands exactly where I left her, silver-white hair, black armor, new saber burning gold at her hip, Vharos on the dark floor behind her. Chat keeps moving. I focus on a message long enough to recognize my own name. The rest smears.

The ringing has swollen until it seems to occupy the space where everyone's voices used to be. My arms are getting harder to move, the weight settling through them so gradually that I only understand how bad it is when I reach for my headset and my hand rises halfway before stopping.

I try again, catch one earcup with my fingers, and drag it off. It lands beside my keyboard, and Discord becomes a faint spill of voices through the speakers.

"Maya? Can you hear me?"

My phone is less than a foot away. I know what to do. Pick it up. Call somebody.

My arm moves several inches before the muscles give out. My fingertips scrape the desk. I try again, staring at the phone's black screen. My elbow trembles. Nothing.

I stop trying to remember when I bought the eggs.

Mom keeps her phone charging on the nightstand with the volume too low. I complain about it every time she misses one of my calls. If she doesn't pick up the first time, I'll call again.

I plant my palm against the desk and try to push myself closer. My arm folds. I catch myself on both forearms before I can slide out of the chair, and the movement sends another slow wave through the room. Lowering my forehead onto my arms eases it a little. The skin there is cool against my face.

Just until the room stops. Then the phone.

Liam's voice leaks from the headset beside me, joined by several others now, the urgency legible even where the words aren't. Someone says ambulance. Someone asks where I live.

I know my address. Of course I know my address. I try to give it to them, and nothing useful leaves my mouth.

I can see Nyx's boots from here. The lower edge of her armor, firelight on obsidian. I try to lift my head enough to see the rest, and nothing happens.

Class at nine. I need to call Mom. My phone.

“Maya?”

The last thing I know about Earth is the hiss of my headset, the smell of overcooked eggs, and eleven people watching Nyx stand victorious over a dead king.

Cold touches my cheek.

I flinch away from it without opening my eyes, turning my face into something soft and damp, and another drop lands near my temple and slides into my hair. For a while I lie there trying to understand why my ceiling is leaking on me. The thought doesn’t survive long. My ceiling is six feet above my bed, for one thing. Also I’m not in my bed. I wasn’t even in bed. I was at my desk.

My eyes open.

Gray fills my vision, enormous and shifting. It isn't drywall and it isn't the weak predawn light that leaks through the bent blinds in my bedroom. It moves, clouds folding over one another across a sky so wide my brain refuses to make sense of it.

A raindrop hits me directly in the eye.

"Fuck."

I squeeze it shut, turn my head, and grass brushes my lips. Actual grass.

I go still. Rain taps against leaves somewhere nearby, thousands of soft impacts gathering into a steady whisper. Something cold has soaked through the side of my shirt. Damp earth presses against my hip and shoulder, and the air smells green and wet, rich with soil and crushed plants and something faintly sweet I can't place.

I push myself onto one elbow, and the world tilts hard enough that I stop there, breathing through a wave of nausea that brings the eggs back with unfortunate clarity. The eggs. My desk. Liam saying my name through the headset. My phone sitting just out of reach. Mom. I remember trying to get to it, and then nothing.

"What the fuck?"

My voice disappears into the rain. I sit up, and forget about the eggs.

I'm in a clearing. Tall grass bends beneath the rain in every direction, silver-green blades brushing my bare legs, tiny white flowers clustered among them with their petals folded tight against the weather. Beyond the clearing a forest rises beneath the bruised sky, and for several seconds all I can do is stare.

The trees are enormous. Their pale trunks climb straight out of the dark undergrowth, broad enough that I couldn't get both arms around one even with three people helping, smooth ivory bark darkening in the rain, the lowest branches beginning high enough to scrape the roof off my apartment building. The leaves are wrong too, long and narrow and almost blue beneath the clouds, overlapping in dense layers that turn everything past them into shadow. Rain catches along their edges before spilling toward the ground in shining streams, and mist moves slowly between the trunks.

I stare up through the pale branches until rain runs into my open mouth. I've scrolled past pictures like this and assumed somebody was lying about the filters.

Then I turn my head.

The clearing slopes gently downward before disappearing into another stretch of forest, and beyond that, through a break in the trees, mountains cut across the horizon. Jagged black ridges spear up through banks of cloud, their highest peaks lost completely inside the storm. Waterfalls thread down the nearest slopes in thin white lines, too distant to hear, bright enough to see whenever the clouds shift.

I have never seen those mountains.

I get to my feet too fast. Blood drains out of my head, the clearing lurches sideways, and I stagger before catching myself with one hand against the wet ground.

“Okay.”

My breathing sounds too loud out here. I straighten more carefully and look down at myself. Bare feet planted in wet grass. Black sleep shorts plastered against my thighs. An oversized T-shirt with CRIT HAPPENS printed across the chest. No bra. My shirt clings cold against my nipples. I pull it away from my skin.

I pat my pockets even though I already know what’s going to happen. Nothing. Of course nothing, they’re sleep shorts. I check again anyway, then turn and scan the grass around me, because my phone could have fallen somewhere, except I remember it sitting on my desk, and my desk isn’t here. Neither is my chair. Or my computer. Or my apartment.

I look toward the forest. There has to be something beyond it. A road. A campground. A house. Some asshole with a camera about to leap out from behind one of those trees and explain whatever elaborate prank I’ve somehow become important enough to deserve.

I turn, listening. No engine, no traffic, no voices. Just rain striking leaves.

There aren’t mountains anywhere near home. There’s a hill on the way to campus that my car complains about. That’s it.

Maybe someone moved me. Drugged me. But Liam was there, and the stream was running. Someone would have seen.

I look down at my hands. Same short nails. Same tiny white scar beside my left thumb from opening a can when I was twelve and refusing to wait for anybody to find the real can opener. I touch my face, fingertips moving over my nose, my cheek, my mouth, then shove wet hair away from my forehead.

I'm me. So where the fuck am I?

Something clamps around my chest. I drag in a breath and it stops halfway. I try again, harder, and somehow get less air.

"No."

My hands are shaking. I press them against my thighs. A hospital. I could be dreaming in a hospital.

I squeeze my eyes shut. My heart pounds harder in the darkness, and when I open them there are pale trunks and blue-black leaves and mountains and rain.

A sound slips out of me, small and thin, and I don't recognize it as mine until another one tries to follow. My lungs start working too fast. Air keeps stopping high in my chest, each breath arriving before the last one has finished, and my fingers are tingling, and then my lips. I know this. I'm breathing too fast. Slow down.

I can't.

I wrap my arms around myself and turn, searching the clearing again, though I've stopped knowing what I'm searching for. A road. A person. My apartment.

I want my phone. The need hits so hard my hand goes to my empty pocket again. I want my apartment. I want the stupid cabinet that doesn't close unless I kick the bottom corner. I want Liam yelling through my headset. I want my desk, my bed, my fucking shoes.

"Hello?"

It comes out too quiet. Nothing answers. I try again, louder, and my voice cracks halfway through.

"Hello! Is anybody—"

The forest takes it. There's no echo, nothing coming back off the trees. It's like yelling into a pillow.

Rain slides down my face. I wipe at it, and my hand comes away wet, and I don't know how much of it is rain anymore.

"Help! Somebody, please!"

I claw at the collar of my shirt and drag it away from my throat. It doesn't help. Air keeps coming in tiny useless pieces, my lungs fluttering faster while my heart hammers so violently that for one insane second I'm certain I died at my desk and I'm dying again now.

Liam saw me collapse. He'll call someone. They'll find my apartment, and they'll call my parents, and Mom is going to think I'm dead.

That one gets me all the way to the ground.

I make a strangled sound and clamp both hands over my mouth, which only makes the next breath worse, so I rip them away. My vision pulses at the edges. Some part of me keeps waiting for reality to snap back into place, for my bedroom to appear around me, for Liam's voice to come through the headset, for anybody at all to answer.

The rain thickens instead. Drops strike hard enough now to flatten the little white flowers around my feet, and wind pushes through the clearing, cold against my soaked shirt, carrying the smell of stone and leaves and distant water.

Then the sky growls, low and far away.

I freeze. The sound rolls across the mountains, deep enough that I feel a faint vibration beneath my bare feet. A pale flash flickers somewhere behind the clouds, and the answering crack comes harder.

Every hair on my arms rises.

The next flash lights the grass all the way to the trees. I'm out in the middle of it, barefoot. I crouch before I know what I'm doing.

"Okay." My voice shakes badly enough that the word barely exists. I swallow. "Okay, Maya."

I don't have to understand where I am. Not right now. I don't have to understand how I got here. Another flash turns the clouds white and the thunder answers sooner, and the only thing I have to do is get out of the open. One thing. I can do one thing.

I look toward the nearest trees. The forest that seemed beautiful ten minutes ago now looks deep enough to swallow me, darkness gathering between the pale trunks, mist crawling low through undergrowth I can't identify. I have no idea what lives in there. Snakes. Bears. Wolves. People. Something I don't have a name for.

My feet won't move.

Thunder rolls again, closer, and I force one foot forward, then the other, and somewhere between the middle of the clearing and the treeline I start counting the way Dad taught me on the porch the summer I was seven. One thousand one. One thousand two.

The thunder comes before I reach three.

I go in.